

Startup Operational Excellence

Appendices Draft

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Appendix A: Operational Audit Question Bank

Use this appendix when the business feels heavier than it should and you need to see what is actually happening.

Do not try to answer every question in one sitting. Choose one customer path, one workflow, or one recurring problem. Then use the questions that help you see the truth more clearly.

Follow The Customer Request

1. Where does the customer request first arrive?
2. Who sees it first?
3. Where is the customer's name, contact information, and need captured?
4. What happens if the founder is busy when the request arrives?
5. What information must be collected before the next step can happen?
6. Where does that information live?
7. What step depends on memory?
8. What step depends on a message thread, note, or old email?
9. What does the customer see while waiting?
10. What confirms that the request has moved forward?

Where Does The Work Wait?

10. Where does the work pause most often?
11. Is the pause caused by missing information, unclear ownership, tool friction, customer delay, founder review, or cash timing?
12. How long does the pause usually last?
13. Who notices the pause first?
14. Does the customer know what is happening during the pause?
15. Does the team know what is needed to restart the work?
16. Is the wait point visible in a shared system?
17. What one field, checklist, owner, or reminder would make the wait easier to

manage?

What Lives Only In Someone's Head?

18. Which customer details depend on memory?
19. Which exceptions are known by one person only?
20. Which passwords, files, links, templates, or instructions are hard to find?
21. Which decision rules have never been written down?
22. Which quality standard is understood but not documented?
23. Which promise would be difficult for someone else to fulfill if the founder

were unavailable?

24. What should be moved from memory into a visible system this week?

Tool Check: Helpful System Or Expensive Habit?

25. What job is this tool supposed to do?
26. Does the team trust the information inside it?
27. Does it reduce work, or does it create another place to check?
28. Does it connect to the customer path, delivery path, or money path?
29. Is it solving a proven problem or preserving an old hope?
30. Would the business break if this tool disappeared for thirty days?
31. Is this tool still runway, or has it become clutter?

Appendix B: Workflow Mapping Worksheet

Use this worksheet to map one real process. Start with a process that already

matters: first contact to proposal, proposal to delivery, delivery to invoice,

or invoice to follow-up.

Current-State Map

Process name:

Customer or internal trigger:

Desired outcome:

Step	Owner	Tool / Location	Input Needed	Output Created	Wait Point	Common Failure
1						
2						
3						
4						
5						
6						
7						

Value Check

For each step, ask:

- 32. Does this step serve the customer?
- 33. Does this step protect the work?
- 34. Does this step reduce risk?
- 35. Does this step prepare the next person to act?
- 36. Does this step only exist because the system is unclear?

Improvement Notes

Remove:

Combine:

Clarify:

Automate later:

Keep manual for now:

Next visible improvement:

Appendix C: Resource Allocation Scorecard

Use this scorecard when the business has more ideas than capacity.

Score each active project, offer, or commitment from 1 to 5. A 1 means weak or unclear. A 5 means strong and obvious.

Item	Revenue Potential	Customer Value	Strategic Fit	Delivery Capacity	Cash Impact	Learning Value	Total

Interpretation

High score, high capacity:

Do this deliberately. Assign the next action and owner.

High score, low capacity:

Protect the opportunity, but reduce scope or delay until capacity is real.

Low score, high effort:

Stop, pause, or redesign. Effort is not proof of value.

Unclear score:

Run a small test before making a large commitment.

Capacity Questions

- 37. Who has to act for this to move forward?
- 38. What existing promise would be delayed if we say yes?
- 39. What decision does the founder need to make?
- 40. What could be delegated if the standard were clearer?
- 41. What can be scheduled, reduced, paused, or removed?

Appendix D: Tool Spend Review Checklist

Use this checklist before adding, renewing, upgrading, or cancelling a tool.

Tool Record

Tool name:

Monthly or annual cost:

Owner:

Primary job:

Connected workflow:

Renewal date:

Review Questions

- 42. What problem did this tool originally promise to solve?
- 43. Is that problem still real?
- 44. Does the tool support lead flow, delivery, money, proof, learning, or compliance?
- 45. Is the data inside the tool accurate enough to trust?
- 46. Who uses it weekly?
- 47. What workaround exists because this tool is confusing or incomplete?
- 48. What would happen if the tool were paused for thirty days?
- 49. Is there a free or lower-cost tool that can carry the current stage?
- 50. Has real demand justified an upgrade?
- 10. Does this tool remove a proven bottleneck or create a prettier version of confusion?

Decision

Keep:

Cancel:

Downgrade:

Upgrade:

Keep manual for one more test batch:

Funding trigger that would justify paid support:

Appendix E: Cost And Profitability Review Sheet

Use this sheet when the business is busy but cash still feels tight.

Offer Review

Offer or service:

Price:

Typical delivery time:

Direct costs:

Indirect costs:

Tools used:

Admin time:

Follow-up or support time:

Founder time:

Cost Questions

51. What does this offer cost to deliver in time?

52. What does it cost in software, subcontractors, materials, transaction fees,
and admin?

53. What hidden work happens before or after delivery?

54. Is the founder's attention being treated as free?

55. Does the price include revision, support, onboarding, and follow-up?

56. Does this offer create repeat business, referrals, proof, or strategic
learning?

57. What must change for this offer to create breathing room?

Cash Rhythm

Invoice trigger:

Payment terms:

Follow-up date:

Late payment action:

Proof capture step:

Next pricing or cost action:

Appendix F: Root Cause Analysis Worksheet

Use this worksheet when the same problem keeps coming back.

Problem Statement

What happened?

When did it happen?

Who or what was affected?

What promise, cost, quality issue, or delay did it create?

The Five Whys

58. Why did this happen?

59. Why did that happen?

60. Why did that happen?

61. Why did that happen?

62. Why did that happen?

Stop when the answer points to a system condition you can change.

System Check

Was the standard clear?

Was the owner clear?

Was the information visible?

Was the tool trusted?

Was the timing realistic?

Was the person trained?

Was the handoff complete?

Was the business relying on memory?

Update The System

Process to update:

SOP to update:

Tool or tracker to update:

Person to inform:

Date to review:

How we will know the fix worked:

Appendix G: SOP Update Checklist

Use this checklist whenever the business learns something that should change

how the work is done.

SOP Identity

SOP name:

Owner:

Last updated:

Workflow supported:

Trigger for update:

Update Checklist

63. Does the SOP name the trigger that starts the work?

64. Does it name the owner of each major step?

65. Does it show where information lives?

66. Does it define what "done" means?

67. Does it name the tools, templates, links, or files needed?

68. Does it include common exceptions?

69. Does it show when to escalate?

70. Does it include proof, follow-up, or learning steps?

71. Does it remove outdated instructions?

10. Can a capable person follow it without asking the founder to translate?

Change Note

What changed:

Why it changed:

Who needs to know:

When it should be reviewed again:

Final Question

Does this SOP make the business more truthful, trustworthy, teachable, or able to keep its promise?